

Nobody Looks Like



Illustrations by
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By Emily Leha

A story about friendship, genetics, and appreciating
human differences rather than letting them get in the way
of what truly matters.

Dedicated to my family.

When Amanda came home from her first day of school, she was **confused**. She stopped in the doorway with a puzzled look on her face and crossed her arms. Her dad, walking in the hallway, noticed Amanda's expression and paused.

"What's the matter, sweetie?" he asked.

Amanda scratched her head. "I met a lot of new classmates today at school, which I expected," she said. "But I didn't expect them to be so **different from me.**"

"What do you mean?"



Amanda recalled how her first day of school had gone. She was starting at a new school, so she had been excited to meet all of her new classmates. She yearned to make a best friend that was **just like her**.



That morning, she wore her favourite headband in her brown frizzy hair. She picked out her best outfit. She practised her smile in the mirror. She liked the way her eyes — one **brown**, one **green** — crinkled when she smiled.

Amanda walked into her new classroom with her backpack and a big smile, ready to greet her new classmates. But when she took a closer look around the room, she hesitated.

She saw people with **black** hair and **blonde** hair, people with **blue** eyes and **brown** eyes, people with pale skin and dark skin, tall people and short people... But she couldn't find anyone that looked just like her!



“Dad, I’m confused,” said Amanda. “Why doesn’t anyone look like me? **Is there something wrong with me?**”

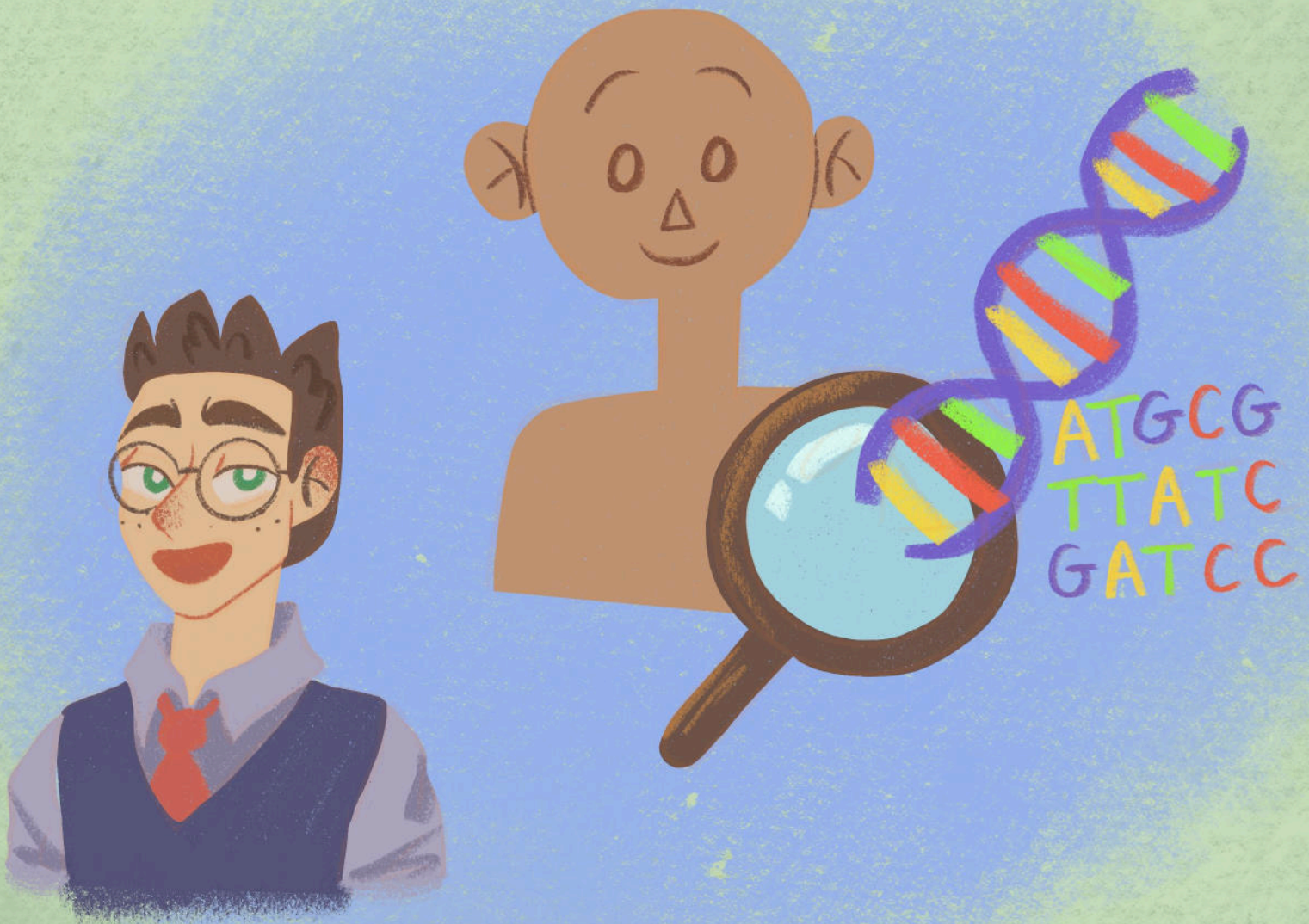
Amanda’s dad took her to the couch and sat her down. “**Not at all,**” he reassured her. “Everybody looks different because everybody is built uniquely.”

“What do you mean?”



Amanda's dad rubbed his hands together excitedly. He was a science teacher, and he absolutely adored giving scientific explanations to his daughter.

"Deep, deep, inside of us is something called **DNA**. DNA determines how we look on the outside," he explained. "Some parts of it are different for everyone. We all look different because we all have **different little parts**."



"So you have **blonde** hair, and I have **brown** hair, because we have different parts of DNA?" asked Amanda.

"Exactly!" Her dad gave her a nod of encouragement.

Amanda took a moment to think about what her father had just explained to her. Amanda's hair was **brown and frizzy** because of her DNA. On the other hand, some of her dad's DNA was different, so his hair was **blonde** instead. Another question came to her mind.

"Why do **Mom and I** have brown hair, but **you** have blonde hair?" she asked her dad.

"Good question," he said. "Your traits are passed down **from your parents**. So even though I have blonde hair, Mom has brown hair. You get your brown hair from your mom, not me."



“There’s a girl at school that has **green streaks** in her hair,” Amanda mused. “Does that mean her mom has green hair, too?”

Amanda’s dad laughed. “Not exactly. She wasn’t born with green hair, so it’s not a trait she got from her parents,” he explained. “It’s likely that she just used **hair dye** to turn it green.”

“I understand now,” replied Amanda. “Thanks, Dad!”



Later that evening, Amanda was sitting at the dinner table with her parents. Dinner had just been served, and it looked delicious. But she was still too preoccupied to eat.

“What’s on your mind, Amanda?” her mom inquired.

“Well, I understand that we’re all unique because we have different DNA, but...” Amanda sighed. “I’m a little bummed that I’ll never be able to make a best friend that’s **just like me.**”



Her dad let out a chuckle. “Amanda, did you know that the DNA between any two humans is **mostly identical**? Only a tiny bit of your DNA is actually different!”

Amanda’s eyes lit up. “Really? So **I’m not so different** after all?”

“Exactly,” her mom chimed in. “And anyway, you and your friend might have **more in common** than just outward appearances.”

Amanda pondered her parents’ words. Feeling inspired, she decided she would try something new the next day at school.



The next morning, Amanda marched into her classroom with purpose. She thought about everything she had learned the previous night about **DNA and human differences**.

Even though nobody else in this classroom looked exactly like her, **she was okay with it**. She knew that she could still make a new best friend.



Amanda took a deep breath, walked up to the girl with **green-streaked** hair, and gave her a friendly wave. "Hi! I'm Amanda."
"Nice to meet you," the girl grinned back at her. "I'm **Zoe**."
"I like your hair," said Amanda.
"Thanks! Green is **my favourite colour**," replied Zoe.
"Green is my favourite colour **too!**"





The two girls laughed. And suddenly, it didn't seem so complicated. Amanda had already found a similarity with Zoe. Even though they were different, in some ways, **they were also the same.**

Amanda smiled to herself. Maybe she could make a best friend that was **just like her** after all.

**The
End**

About the Author



Emily Leha is a student at Western University originally from Ottawa, Ontario. Inspired by the diverse world around her, she wrote this story to help children see that we are all more alike than we realize. When not studying hard for an upcoming Medical Sciences test, she enjoys reading, tennis, playing the flute and piano, and traveling.

About the Illustrators



Amy Shi is a Medical Sciences student at Western University in London, Ontario. She is specializing in Microbiology and Immunology but also loves being creative via illustration. Aside from science and visual arts, she also likes to play games on her switch, try making new recipes, and grow her collection of blind box figurines.



Sophie Smith is a Microbiology and Immunology student at Western University in London, Ontario. When she's not running experiments or volunteering, she likes to go cafe-hopping to find the best matcha in the city and channel her creativity into digital illustration.

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